Producers, consumers and decomposers

All the organisms in an ecosystem can be grouped into one of three types, depending on what they eat.

- **Producers** are living things that make (or produce) their own food from inorganic (non-living) ingredients. Examples of producers are green plants.
- **Consumers** are organisms that cannot make their own food. They either eat or use food products made by producers or other living things that eat producers. Examples of consumers are insects and snakes.
- **Decomposers** break down organic matter (dead plants and animals) by making it rot or decay, releasing nutrients, and then absorb the nutrients as food. Examples of decomposers are bacteria and fungi. Many decomposers are microscopic organisms, called microorganisms.

☞ **1 a)** In the diagram below, colour any producers GREEN and any consumers RED.

b) Can you see any decomposers? Why or why not?



ISBN 978 1 92571 064 9
© Ally Chumley and Blake Education 2014

Producers, consumers and decomposers CONT'D

2 Complete the table by giving examples of producers, consumers and decomposers for each ecosystem. Some examples have been given. Work alone or with a partner.

	Australian desert ecosystem	**African savannah ecosystem**
Producers	spinifex grass kangaroo paw Sturt's desert rose	
Consumers		
Decomposers		fungi bacteria termites

3 Write definitions for the following words. Use your dictionary if needed.

a) organic _____

_____

b) inorganic _____

_____

© Ally Chumley and Blake Education 2014
ISBN 978 1 92571 064 9